

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #010 — Phase 1, Film 1: Full Film Sheet
CONFIDENTIAL • An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf
Tolerance: 0%

HITSVILLE

Phase 1, Film 1 • The Iron Man role • May 1, 2009

Motown Productions • Distributed by Paramount Pictures • PG-13 • approx. 155 min

1. Title: *Hitsville*

- The title comes from the real sign Gordy hung on the front of 2648 West Grand Boulevard: **HITSVILLE U.S.A.**
- It's short, bold and easy to remember, just like *Iron Man*. To the public it names a building, so it gives nothing away (Memo #007).

Title considered	Verdict
Hitsville	SELECTED. Real, iconic, and it names the hub the whole universe grows from.
To Be Loved	Rejected. It's the title of Gordy's memoir and of a Jackie Wilson song he co-wrote, but it's too soft for a launch film.
Money (That's What I Want)	Rejected. The song was co-written with Janie Bradford and doesn't belong to Gordy alone. It also makes his story sound only about money.
Motown	Rejected. It's too broad and too close to the franchise brand, so it would risk the secret.

2. What's Being Adapted

Berry Gordy's real life and the founding of Motown, roughly 1955 to early 1961. The film is based on these sources:

Source	Used for
Primary: Berry Gordy, <i>To Be Loved: The Music, the Magic, the Memories of Motown</i> (1994)	The main structure and Gordy's point of view
Raynoma Gordy Singleton, <i>Berry, Me, and Motown</i> (1990)	Raynoma's role in the founding years, told from her side

Source	Used for
Smokey Robinson, <i>Smokey: Inside My Life</i> (1989)	Smokey and Gordy's partnership and the Miracles
The master recordings, label credits, and the Billboard chart record	Every song, credit, release date and chart position shown on screen
Documented Motown corporate history (founding Jan 12, 1959; incorporation Apr 14, 1960)	Fixed points on the timeline

3. What the Movie Is About

Logline: A Detroit assembly-line worker whose hit songs earn him almost nothing borrows \$800 from his family, turns a two-story house into a hit factory, and builds the biggest Black-owned record company in America.

Act One — The Line (mid-1950s to 1958)

Berry Gordy is a former boxer, an Army veteran, and a failed jazz-record-store owner. He works on a Lincoln-Mercury assembly line and writes songs in his head as the cars go by. He starts writing for Jackie Wilson. “Reet Petite” and “Lonely Teardrops” become hits, but the money never matches the success. He meets a teenage Smokey Robinson, who carries a notebook full of songs, and Raynoma Liles, a gifted musician who becomes his partner in work and in life. When Gordy leases his productions to other labels, he keeps losing both money and control. Smokey pushes him with one question: why not start his own label?

Act Two — The House (1959 to 1960)

Gordy goes to his family's savings fund. After a family vote and a signed loan agreement, he gets **\$800**. He wants to name his label “Tammy,” but the name is taken, so it becomes **Tamla** (January 12, 1959). He buys 2648 West Grand Boulevard, lives upstairs, builds a studio in the back, and hangs the **HITSVILLE U.S.A.** sign. He recruits jazz musicians from Detroit's clubs for the house band. Barrett Strong's “Money (That's What I Want)” becomes a national hit. Gordy brings the assembly-line method to music: writing, producing, artist development and quality control. On April 14, 1960, he incorporates **Motown Record Corporation**.

Act Three — The Million (late 1960 to early 1961)

“Shop Around” by Smokey Robinson & the Miracles is already out, but Gordy isn't satisfied. He calls Smokey in the middle of the night to re-record it at a faster tempo. It's a huge risk: he's pulling a released record, with the company's money on the line. The new version reaches **#1 R&B and #2 on the Hot 100** and becomes the label's **first million-seller**. The last image is the HITSVILLE U.S.A. sign lighting up over West Grand Boulevard.

4. Whose Movie / Franchise It Is

Berry Gordy's. This is his solo origin story, and he anchors the whole Motown Universe the way Tony Stark anchored the MCU. Every artist who comes through Hitsville comes through his story. He's shown at full strength (No-Nerf): the genius, the charm, the drive and the controlling streak, all as documented.

5. Antagonist

Level	Antagonist	What the record supports
Primary	The late-1950s record-business system	Tiny songwriter royalties, lease deals that took away the producer's control, distributors who paid late or not at all, and segregated charts and radio that held Black music back. This plays the role Obadiah Stane played in Iron Man: the system that profits from the hero's genius.
Human face	The business side of Jackie Wilson's career, run by his manager Nat Tarnopol	Limited to the documented fact that Gordy's hits for Wilson paid him very little, and to the split that followed. Nothing beyond the record is added.
Internal	Gordy himself	His need for control and his all-or-nothing gambles, such as pulling a released record. His strengths are also his biggest risks.

No made-up villains (Memo #008). The Gordy family's doubts about the loan are shown as a real obstacle, not as villainy.

6. Timeline: When & Where

	Setting
When	Mid-1950s to February 1961. The main action runs from 1957 to 1961. The first fixed point is Tamla's founding on Jan 12, 1959, and the last is "Shop Around" peaking in early 1961.
Where	Detroit, Michigan: a Lincoln-Mercury assembly plant, the Flame Show Bar, the Gordy family businesses and home, the clubs where the house band was recruited, and above all Hitsville U.S.A., 2648 West Grand Boulevard , including the studio in the back.
Master timeline	TMU Chapter One. Every other TMU film is set on or after this film's dates.

7. Standalone World-Building

- **Gordy's Detroit:** Black Detroit in the auto-plant era, including the assembly lines, the jazz clubs and the Flame Show Bar.
- **The Gordy family:** Pops and Bertha Gordy, the family businesses and savings fund, and the siblings who become the company's backbone: Esther, Anna, Gwen, Loucy and others.

- **Gordy's personal arc:** from boxer, soldier and failed record-store owner to songwriter and then founder, with Raynoma as his creative partner in the founding years.
- **A complete story:** the film begins with the loan and ends with the million-seller. A first-time viewer needs nothing else (40% serialized / 60% standalone, Memo #005).

8. Motown Universe World-Building

Everything below is real history. To the public it looks like ordinary accuracy, which keeps the secret (Memo #007).

Type	Established in Hitsville
Settings	Hitsville U.S.A. and its studio, built as permanent sets for the whole universe (Memo #005). This is the universe's headquarters.
Characters	Berry Gordy (the universe's anchor), Smokey Robinson & the Miracles (the first act), Esther Gordy Edwards and the Gordy family (the company's management), Raynoma Liles, Barrett Strong, Janie Bradford, and the first musicians of the house band that becomes the Funk Brothers.
Cameos (seeds)	Mary Wells (1960), a teenager who brings Gordy a song meant for Jackie Wilson, "Bye Bye Baby," and records it herself. The Primettes (1960), who audition and are told to come back after finishing high school. They'll return as the Supremes. Marvin Gaye at the piano at a Gordy family Christmas party (Dec. 1960).
Plot elements	The assembly-line method, the origin of Motown's quality control (the "Shop Around" re-recording), the Motown Record Corporation, and the leasing-versus-owning fight that shapes every later deal.
Cast	Every real person is cast for the long term, with confidential multi-film deals (Memo #007). The same actors return in later films.

9. Post-Credits Scenes: Two

Scene	Setting	What happens
Mid-credits	Hitsville U.S.A., 1961	Ronnie White of the Miracles brings an 11-year-old blind boy, Stevland Morris, to audition. He plays every instrument in the room. Gordy signs him. It introduces a future star at full strength, and no one says he'll matter again.
End-credits	Hitsville U.S.A., 1962	Esther Gordy Edwards spreads out a map of tour dates through the South. On the table is a poster: THE MOTORTOWN REVUE . This is the TMU's version of Nick Fury's "Avengers Initiative" moment. It's real history, and it teases the team (Memo #006) without saying so.

Both scenes are shot under sealed security with a minimal crew and cut in late (Memo #007).

10. How It Kicks Everything Off

- **It establishes the founder.** Berry Gordy becomes the anchor of the universe, and every future film connects back to him.
- **It builds the headquarters.** Hitsville U.S.A. becomes the shared setting for the universe, as Stark Industries and later Avengers Tower did for the MCU.
- **It sets the method.** The assembly line and quality control become the house rules every later artist lives under.
- **It launches the first act.** Smokey Robinson & the Miracles give the universe its first star and its first million-seller.
- **It plants the future.** Mary Wells, the Primettes and Marvin Gaye appear as cameos, and the mid-credits scene brings in Stevland Morris. Each is set up for a later full-strength story.
- **It hints at the team.** The Motortown Revue poster is the first sign of the team-up, and the public won't recognize it yet.
- **It locks the timeline.** Jan 12, 1959, Apr 14, 1960 and early 1961 become the first fixed points on the master timeline.

11. Compliance Check

Mandate	Status
Fidelity (Memo #001)	PASS. Every event, song, credit and date comes from the documented record.
No-Nerf (Memo #001)	PASS. Gordy, Smokey and every cameo appear at full documented strength.
Studio (Memos #002–#003)	PASS. Motown Productions, distributed by Paramount.
Phase (Memo #004)	PASS. Phase 1, Film 1 of 6. Released May 1, 2009.
Story model (Memo #005)	PASS. 40% serialized / 60% standalone.
Format (Memo #005)	PASS. Musical Biographical Drama, PG-13, approx. 155 min.
Secrecy (Memo #007)	PASS. Publicly marketed as the true story of Motown's founder, with no universe branding.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal, Paramount or Marvel Studios. The people named are real. The film and the roles here are fictional.